

Charting mere catholicity: the historic communions

What has been believed everywhere, always, and by all.

Rome, the Orthodox of the East and the Orient, and the confessional churches of the Reformation, graded row by row from their own binding standards against the faith the whole Church received.

The charting papers, part one of three.

The chart below sorts the dogmas the whole Church has received from the claims she has not. Where does that list of received dogmas come from, and why does it stop? The rule is older than the divisions that made this chart necessary. In the year 434, before Chalcedon, before the Great Schism, centuries before the Reformation, a monk of the island of Lérins named St. Vincent wrote down the test the Church already lived by: hold **what has been believed everywhere, always, and by all**. That is the line at the head of this page, and it is a working tool, not a slogan. Each of the three words is a knife. **Everywhere** cuts away whatever was only regional, one country's custom, one see's usage. **Always** cuts away whatever arrived later, however venerable the century that added it. **By all** cuts away the positions of parties and schools, and even the private opinions of the greatest saints, for no single doctor is the measure, the consensus is. Put the whole of Christian teaching to those three knives and most of it falls away. What survives all three is the catholic core, and it is small on purpose.

And St. Vincent's rule does not work alone, for the Church has organs to apply it. The seven ecumenical councils are where the whole Church spoke, gathered from East and West to define the faith against error. The consensus of the Fathers is where her teachers agree across centuries, languages, and continents, no one of them the measure alone. And the *sensus fidelium* is the instinct of the whole baptized people, who were praying to Christ as God and reading the Scriptures as canon before any council said so. The three witnesses check one another. A council defines, the Fathers show the definition was the faith already held, and the people receive it into their worship, and where all three agree the teaching is authoritative. That agreement is what the chart's green marks are made of.

And where does Scripture stand in this? Above everything, as the supreme witness of the faith, God-breathed and clear in the things necessary for salvation, read within the Church that received it and not against her. Scripture is also the proof that reception needs no infallible referee. Rome objects that without a living court to settle every question, nothing is ever settled. But ask how the Church got her Bible. No pope and no council of the undivided age ever closed the canon of Scripture by decree. The Church received it core first and edges slowly, the Gospels and Paul held everywhere from the beginning, the disputed edges tolerated for centuries, and East and West differ at the margins still. If reception without a referee were not enough, there would be no Bible to argue from. Meanwhile the court that claims to be the bedrock has reversed its own teaching in both directions, and a bedrock cannot do that. The bedrock is not a court. It is the living God, whose will is made known in His Word and borne by His whole Church in the life of the Holy Spirit.

A council binds when the whole body of believers comes to confess it, so the received rows are the faith that already binds all Christians, and the set-down rows stand as each part's own teaching, not yet received by the whole and not a condition any part may exact of the rest.

The chart grades confessions, not Christians. Every column baptizes into the one Body, and every red X among the received rows is healable by the hand that set it. Each column's case follows the chart.

	The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE CHURCH IN THE FIRST MILLENNIUM								

	The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
<i>Catholicity together</i>	The Holy Scriptures	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	The Nicene Creed	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	The christology of the seven councils	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
	Mary the Theotokos, Mother of God (Ephesus)	✓	✓	✓	?§	✓	✓	?§
	The veneration of the holy icons (Nicaea II)	✓	✓	✓	?***	✓***	?***	✗***
	The apostolic succession of bishops	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓†	?*	?*
	The real presence in the Eucharist (corporeal)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗**
	The regeneration given in Baptism	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	?§§
	The moral consensus of the Fathers (life, marriage, holy orders) ‡	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

	The faith confessed	Roman Catholic	Eastern Orthodox	Oriental Orthodox	Assyrian	High Anglican	Confessional Lutheran	Presbyterian
DEFINED SINCE THE SCHISMS BY ONE PART OF THE DIVIDED CHURCH, AND SO NOT YET RECEIVED BY THE WHOLE								
Set down, not thrown away, awaiting reception	Papal infallibility, Vatican I (1870)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	The Marian definitions (1854 and 1950)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	Trent's anathemas on justification (1547)	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	The Palamite councils (1341 to 1351)	✗	✓	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	The Thirty- Nine Articles as binding (1571) ††	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗
	The Augsburg Confession as binding (1530)	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓	✗
	The Westminster Standards as binding (1646)	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓

* Their pastors are ordained by presbyters rather than bishops, and whether presbyteral succession preserves the ministry is a real question, worked out in The bishop and the presbyter. The book records both readings, walks the narrower in its own map, and does not close the question.

† Claimed and maintained in the historic line, and contested. Rome denied these orders in 1896, by an act the book declines to treat as final, and the question stands open, healable by the party that raised it. The book grades these altars contested rather than settled.

** On the presence the Reformed standards affirm a true feeding on Christ's body and blood, yet spiritually, to faith, not carnally and corporally, the elements remaining truly and only bread and wine (Westminster Confession 29), which refuses the confessed thing itself, not merely a formula for it, so the mark stands. It is worth saying exactly why it holds, for their own best doctors, Calvin himself and the Mercersburg divines after him, pressed this spiritual feeding toward the ancient realism. Calvin's own treatise on the Supper confesses that "we are truly made partakers of the proper substance of the body and blood of Jesus Christ" (Short Treatise on the Lord's Supper, 1541), and Nevin's *Mystical Presence* of 1846 argued that the original Reformed doctrine was "a real communication with his substantial, personal, mediatorial life." The school has a name, Mercersburg theology, from the seminary where Nevin and Philip Schaff taught, called by its friends high church Presbyterianism or sacramental Calvinism, in our day Reformed catholicity, and its own name for its program was Evangelical Catholicism, the claim that the Reformed tradition at its best is a catholic tradition. Its high-water marks are confessional, not private. The Belgic Confession calls what we eat and drink "the true, natural body and the true blood of Christ," and the Scots Confession of 1560 utterly damns those who say the sacraments are naked and bare signs. Princeton read Calvin down, and though scholars now grant that Nevin had the history right, it was Princeton's lower reading that the Presbyterian churches followed. But the chart grades standards, not schools. The crossings that give this page its hope are cases where the guarded faith was confessed all along in other words and the agreed statements of our own day record the match. Here the standards keep a neighboring grace and refuse the substance, and no agreed statement records otherwise. The mark is healable by the hand that set it, for confessions can be amended, as the American church amended Westminster's own chapters on the civil magistrate in 1788 and subscribes the amended text to this day, and a future agreement can record a match, as 1994 recorded one for the East. What needs doing is plain: chapter 29 amended back toward the tradition's own oldest stratum, Calvin, the Belgic, and the Scots, the church healing itself from its own beginnings. Until then the hope is held as hope, prayed for and not asserted, and a question mark would assert it.

§§ The Reformed standards do not deny the grace of Baptism but untie it from the moment of the act. The grace promised is really exhibited and conferred by the Holy Ghost in God's appointed time (Westminster Confession 28.6), and what is refused is the binding of the gift to the minute of the washing. A grace affirmed but untied is a question, not a refusal, which is why this cell bears a question mark while the Supper's bears a red X.

*** Not iconoclasm on every hand. The Lutheran churches kept the image and the crucifix against the image-breakers, and condemn nothing here. What they do not confess is the seventh council's definition, that the honor given the image passes to its prototype, and the veneration it commands. The book faces the same problem with the Assyrian Church of the East, which uses almost no images at all, and it still places their altars in the first tier, because they venerate the cross and do not condemn what they do not practice. The parallel reaches the Lutheran. The Reformed standards go further and condemn the use itself, and the mark stands accordingly. This is the one row where no school of theirs presses upward, for even Mercersburg left the images alone. If there is a road it is the Assyrian door. The Assyrians stand in the first tier venerating the cross and condemning nothing, so the first Reformed step is not veneration but the end of condemnation, and Larger Catechism 109 can be amended by the same pen that amended 1788. Their practice already argues with their standard, for images of Christ sit in Presbyterian homes and children's Bibles under a catechism that forbids them. One step taken in

fact, one still to take on paper, and the X would soften to a question. The High Anglican check rests on the Continuing churches' Affirmation of St. Louis, which receives the seven councils entire, against the plain sense of Article 22 elsewhere.

§ The Assyrian Church long avoided the title, fearing it divided Christ, and the Common Declaration of 1994 recognized that her own Mother of Christ our God and Saviour confesses the same faith. The formula differs, the faith is received, which is this chart's whole method in one cell. The Westminster standards entail the doctrine, of the substance of the Virgin Mary, but never use the title.

‡ Plainly: life means the ancient witness against abortion and euthanasia, held from the Didache on. Marriage means marriage as the whole Church received it, the union of a man and a woman, and no blessing of sodomy. Holy orders means ordination as the whole Church knew it, reserved to men. This row is why the columns are the conservative wings and not the mainlines. The book makes it a second sorting condition beside the marks, and it is the row on which the Union of Utrecht, which keeps the succession five for five and ordains women, falls off this chart entirely. Orders alone do not carry the deposit.

†† The X runs the whole row, and the Anglican X is the interesting one. The Continuing churches, by the Affirmation of St. Louis, receive the Articles as a historical witness subordinate to the seven councils, not as a binding confession, which makes the High Anglican the one communion on this chart that already holds its own confessional document as patrimony rather than condition, the very act the book asks of every other column. Said with care: the old Church of England bound her clergy to the Articles by subscription, so the X marks the High Anglican as he stands on this chart, not as he stood in 1571.

What catholicity asks of each communion

The Roman Catholic case. What catholicity asks of him is a setting down, of papal infallibility as Vatican I defined it, of the Marian definitions of 1854 and 1950 as binding dogma, of the finality of Trent's anathemas on justification, and a retiring, of the claim that the Roman communion alone is the one true Church, the same claim the East is asked to retire of herself. Set down means set down for him too. He withholds the assent of faith as the Presbyterian officer takes his exception. What the book then asks of Rome herself is the corporate form of the same act, to hold these definitions as her own patrimony, awaiting reception by the whole, acknowledging they are not held by all, and demanding them of no one as a condition of communion, her own son who has set them down included. And the claim to be alone the one true Church is not patrimony to keep but a claim to retire, by Rome and by the East alike. This is dissent toward catholicity, not away from it, disciplined and principled, not renegade. He prays for the Bishop of Rome by name, gives him the obedience the first millennium gave, filial and real but not absolute, makes no faction, and appeals from within. His case is harder than the Presbyterian's, for Rome's present law licenses no exceptions and calls this dissent. He approaches the altar anyway, a son appealing to the whole Body's future reception, standing at her altar without claiming she blesses it, and he bears what may follow without resentment, holding his exceptions for the unity of the whole. That is how catholicity is held in the Roman communion.

The Eastern Orthodox case. His column is green down the received rows, every one, so nothing is asked of his faith. Catholicity asks him to set down the Palamite councils as binding on all, holding them as the East's own patrimony until the whole receives them, and to retire the claim that Orthodoxy alone is the one true Church, which is not a definition awaiting the whole but a claim against it. His discipline is the mirror of the Roman one, make no faction, and let the appeal be lived rather than shouted in his own house. And his advantage is real, and this page owes him the debt said plainly. The Eastern doctrine of reception, that the guardian of the faith is the whole body of the Church, the people themselves, as the Eastern Patriarchs answered Rome in 1848, is the very cure this chart prescribes, widened, for the Encyclical meant by the whole Church her own communion, and the book means the whole divided Body. The medicine and the overdose came in one bottle, and she is asked to keep the medicine and set down the overdose. And one work is asked beyond the setting down, the third profession's live labor, the recognition his communion does not yet extend to the Oriental churches, whose case stands beside his. That is how catholicity is held in the Orthodox communion.

The Oriental Orthodox case. His column is green down the received rows, and his communion is the page's proof rather than its pupil. His fathers refused Chalcedon's formula fearing it divided Christ, confessed the guarded faith in their own words for fifteen centuries, and the agreed statements of our own day record the match, the whole method of this chart demonstrated at scale. So nothing is asked of his faith. What is asked is the live work the book calls the third profession, that his communion and the Eastern Orthodox extend to one another the recognition their common declarations already support, for between those two houses it is not yet in force. And one admission is owed him. The book holds his place as it holds every judgment it makes, provisionally and in hope, on the first-millennium evidence and not as a verdict already in. That is how catholicity is held in the Oriental communion, and it has been held there through fifteen centuries of patience.

The High Anglican case. His is the shortest case on the page, for his column runs green down the received rows and claims nothing alone beneath them. The Continuing churches already hold the Articles as historical witness rather than binding condition, which is the very act this chart asks of every other column, performed already, in 1977. So nothing is asked of his faith and nothing of his paper. His burdens are two, and neither is assent. His orders lie under the doubt of 1896,[†] which only the party that raised it can heal, and his provinces divide over the very moral consensus this chart stakes, so his task is to hold the confession entire and to be, where he stands, the proof that it can be kept. That is how catholicity is held in the Anglican communion.

The Assyrian case. His is the oldest tear on the chart and the smallest communion, and the least is asked of him, because his church already did what this page proposes. She refused the council of Ephesus and confessed the one Christ it defended, in Babai her doctor and in her liturgy, and in 1994 Rome and the Church of the East signed the declaration recording that the faith was one while the formulas differed, the very kind of act the book's proposal multiplies. Her aniconic altars stand in the first tier because she venerates the cross and condemns nothing she does not practice, the door this page keeps pointing the Presbyterian toward. What remains is to carry the recognition of 1994 through with the other ancient communions. That is how catholicity is held in the Assyrian communion, and it has been held there longer than anywhere else, with the least said about it.

The Confessional Lutheran case. His sacraments are already green, the presence confessed without qualification and the grace of Baptism with it, and on the holy icons^{***} he keeps the image, condemns nothing, and stands a step from the Assyrian door. What catholicity asks of him is two things. On the ministry^{*} he is asked to press his communion back toward the episcopate the first millennium knew, owed on either reading, the question the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open. And on Augsburg he is asked what Rome and the East are asked, to hold his confession as patrimony rather than exact it, which his own tradition half remembers, for Augsburg was written as an appeal within the one Church, not as the charter of another. That is how catholicity is held in the Lutheran communion.

The Presbyterian case. The layman takes no subscription vow at all, only his officers do, for his membership vows ask a credible profession of Christ, not the Standards, which is his own polity's design. So from the pew he may confess the whole first millennium without asking anyone's leave. He may hold the regeneration given in Baptism^{ss} on his standard's own words. It is his ministers who must take exception to Westminster's chapter 29 to hold the real presence,^{**} siding, ironically, with Calvin himself and the Mercersburg school of high church Presbyterianism against Princeton's lower reading, and his courts may refuse it, which is why the presence note says the paper itself needs mending. And his own confession agrees, for Westminster teaches that all synods and councils may err and many have, so to hold the Standards as reformable is not to hold them loosely but to hold them on their own terms. And on the holy icons^{***} the Presbyterian road is the Assyrian one, an exception to Larger Catechism 109 that ceases to condemn the veneration Presbyterians do not practice, the very posture that keeps the aniconic Assyrian altars in the first tier. And on the ministry^{*} he is asked to press his communion back toward the episcopate the first millennium knew, owed on either reading, the question the bishop and presbyter paper leaves open. That is how catholicity is held in the Presbyterian communion. And the asking is mutual. Rome is asked to walk back her solo definitions, the East hers, and the Presbyterian is asked to out-confess his own paper, each part holding catholicity together from its own side.

The chart's columns end at Westminster, and most American Christians worship past its edge. The same nine rows measure them too, and the same rule, read the other way: where the older communions are asked to set down, the younger churches are asked to pick up. Part two, charting the free churches, is that page.

The end sought is not ecclesiological tidiness. It is the Lord's high priestly prayer, that they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me (John 17:21).

Continue to part two: the free churches.

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.